

English Ladder

Student Workbook

"Cold" Explanations

A polished self-study handout designed for print or tablet use. Read the concept, notice the pattern, and then complete the matching practice set on your own.



Grammar Concepts #42

Example 1: Laptop

Example 2: Oshibori

Summary of Key Grammar Points

Visual anchor

Use the concept poster to spotlight the main language pattern in **"Cold" Explanations** and keep the explanation visible during practice and discussion.

ENGLISH LADDER

Concept #42 ► **"Cold" Explanations**

When introducing a concept completely unknown to others, following the outline on the right is very useful. Two examples are found below.

- **General Domain**
- **Definition**
- **Examples**
- **Extra Information**

► **Laptop** | A laptop is a type of computer. It is a small computer that is portable enough to use on your lap. Apple and Sony produce many types and sizes of laptops. Laptops have internal batteries, so they do not need to be constantly plugged into a power source. They are often used by office workers in coffee shops.

► **Oshibori** | An oshibori is a wet towel found in Japanese eating establishments. It is a white wet towel typically provided to bar or restaurant customers to wash their hands before eating. Some oshibori are made of cotton, while other disposable oshibori are made of less expensive materials. They often come in thin plastic packages, and they may be scented or contain alcohol for optimal cleaning. The oshibori provided are normally cool in summer and hot in winter. They should be used to clean only your hands. After using an oshibori, you can simply fold it neatly and place it to the side.

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Core Idea

The image presents a structured approach for explaining new or unfamiliar concepts, particularly useful for non-native English speakers. The approach includes four key elements: General Domain, Definition, Examples, and Extra Information. Below, each element is dissected in detail, with a focus on the grammatical principles at play.

Example 1: Laptop

- **General Domain:**Extended Example Sentences:Grammar Focus: The indefinite article "A" or "An" is used here because we are introducing the concept in a general sense. The copular verb "is" is essential for linking the subject to its category or definition. Sentence: "A laptop is a type of computer." Analysis: This sentence begins with the indefinite article "A", which introduces the concept of laptop as a member of a broader category-"type of computer." The use of "is" as a copular verb links the subject "laptop" to its category. The structure follows a noun + be + noun pattern, which is fundamental in English for defining and classifying nouns. "A hybrid car is a type of vehicle that uses both electric and gasoline engines." "A sonnet is a type of poem that consists of 14 lines and follows a specific rhyme scheme."
- **Definition:**Extended Example Sentences:Grammar Focus: The use of a relative clause "that is portable enough to use" adds specificity to the noun "computer." This clause is essential in providing the defining characteristic of the subject, thereby eliminating ambiguity. Sentence: "It is a small computer that is portable enough to use on your lap." Analysis: The sentence uses "It" as a pronoun referring to the previously mentioned laptop. The relative clause "that is portable enough to use on your lap" provides essential information that defines the laptop's functionality and size. The structure "portable enough to" is an adjective phrase that describes a quality of the laptop, followed by an infinitive verb "to use" indicating the purpose. "It is a smartphone that can fit in your pocket and has access to the internet." "It is a bicycle that is designed for off-road cycling."
- **Examples:**Extended Example Sentences:Grammar Focus: The coordination of subjects (Apple and Sony) and objects (types and sizes) through the conjunction "and" demonstrates the use of parallel structure in English. This structure is critical for clarity and balance in sentences. Sentence: "Apple and Sony produce many types and sizes of laptops." Analysis: The sentence includes specific proper nouns "Apple" and "Sony" as the subjects, followed by the transitive verb "produce," which takes the direct object "many types and sizes of laptops." The plural form "types" and "sizes" reflects the diversity and range within the category. "Ford and Tesla manufacture various models and designs of electric cars." "Penguin and HarperCollins publish different genres and formats of books."



- **Extra Information:Extended Example Sentences:Grammar Focus:** The use of coordinating conjunctions like "so" is critical for showing logical relationships between clauses. The placement of adverbs (e.g., often) and prepositional phrases (e.g., by office workers) provides additional context and detail, contributing to the sentence's overall informational depth. Sentences: "Laptops have internal batteries, so they do not need to be constantly plugged into a power source. They are often used by office workers in coffee shops." Analysis: This segment uses a compound sentence connected by the coordinating conjunction "so," indicating a cause-effect relationship. The first clause "Laptops have internal batteries" describes a feature, while the second clause "they do not need to be constantly plugged into a power source" explains the consequence of this feature. The third sentence "They are often used by office workers in coffee shops" uses the adverb "often" to indicate frequency and the prepositional phrase "by office workers in coffee shops" to describe typical users and settings. "Hybrid cars have electric motors, so they consume less fuel and emit fewer pollutants." "Smartphones are equipped with GPS, so they can be used for navigation by travelers."

Example 2: Oshibori

- **General Domain:Extended Example Sentences:Grammar Focus:** The choice between "A" and "An" depends on the sound of the following word, not just the letter. The participial phrase "found in Japanese eating establishments" efficiently condenses additional information into a single descriptive unit. Sentence: "An oshibori is a wet towel found in Japanese eating establishments." Analysis: The indefinite article "An" is used before the noun "oshibori" because the word starts with a vowel sound. The phrase "found in Japanese eating establishments" functions as a participial phrase that acts adjectivally to provide context about where oshibori are typically used. "An espresso is a strong coffee beverage served in small cups in Italian cafes." "A kimono is a traditional garment worn in Japan during formal occasions."
- **Definition:Extended Example Sentences:Grammar Focus:** The use of the passive voice "typically provided" is crucial for focusing on the action (providing the towel) rather than the doer of the action. The infinitive phrase "to wash their hands" clearly indicates the intended use or purpose of the object. Sentence: "It is a white wet towel typically provided to bar or restaurant customers to wash their hands before eating." Analysis: The sentence begins with the pronoun "It" referring back to oshibori. The structure "typically provided" is a passive voice construction, indicating that the oshibori is generally given to customers by someone else. The infinitive verb phrase "to wash their hands before eating" clearly defines the purpose of the oshibori. "It is a scarf often worn in winter to keep the neck warm." "It is a menu typically handed to customers as they are seated in a restaurant."
- **Examples:Extended Example Sentences:Grammar Focus:** The conjunction "while" is effective for drawing contrasts, and the determiners "some" and "other" help in distinguishing between different subsets of a category. This structure is vital for comparing and contrasting items. Sentence: "Some oshibori are made of cotton, while other disposable oshibori are made of less expensive materials." Analysis: The sentence utilizes a compound structure with the conjunction "while" to contrast two types of oshibori. The use of "Some" and "other" as determiners highlights different subsets within the general category. "Some coffees are brewed from Arabica beans, while others are made from Robusta beans." "Some shirts are crafted from silk, while others are produced from synthetic fabrics."



- **Extra Information:**Extended Example Sentences:Grammar Focus: Modal verbs like "may" and "should" play a critical role in expressing nuances of possibility, advice, or necessity. The use of participial phrases (e.g., "After using") allows for smooth transitions between actions and provides a clear sequence of events. Sentences: "They often come in thin plastic packages, and they may be scented or contain alcohol for optimal cleaning. The oshibori provided are normally cool in summer and hot in winter. They should be used to clean only your hands. After using an oshibori, you can simply fold it neatly and place it to the side." Analysis: This section consists of multiple independent clauses connected by coordinating conjunctions, providing a wealth of additional details. The use of modal verbs like "may" and "should" expresses possibility and obligation, respectively. The phrase "for optimal cleaning" functions as an adverbial phrase, explaining the purpose of adding scent or alcohol. The final sentence employs the structure "After using," which is a participial phrase indicating time. "These glasses often come in sturdy cases, and they may be polarized for optimal protection against glare. They should be worn in bright sunlight. After using the glasses, you can place them back in the case to keep them safe." "These masks are usually packaged in individual wrappers, and they may contain a cooling gel for better comfort. They should be worn on your face. After using the mask, you can dispose of it in a bin."

Summary of Key Grammar Points

- **General Domain:** Introduces the concept within a broader category, often using a noun + be + noun structure. Example: "A [Concept] is a type of [General Domain]."
- **Definition:** Provides a specific explanation, using relative clauses and adjective phrases to add precision. Example: "[Concept] is [a specific description or definition]."
- **Examples:** Offers practical instances using compound sentences to compare and contrast different aspects. Example: "[Example 1] and [Example 2] are examples of [Concept]."
- **Extra Information:** Includes additional relevant details using modal verbs, participial phrases, and complex sentence structures to convey purpose, sequence, and context. Example: "[Concept] may also include [extra detail 1] and [extra detail 2]."

This rigorous analysis enhances the ability to explain complex concepts clearly and effectively, which is crucial for non-native English speakers striving for precision and fluency in their communication.

Examples

"Cold" Explanations



Tablet |

A tablet is a type of computer.

It is a portable device with a touchscreen interface.

Brands like Apple (iPad) and Samsung (Galaxy Tab) manufacture different models of tablets.

Tablets can be used for browsing the internet, reading e-books, or watching videos. They are often used by students and professionals for their convenience and versatility.

Thermos |

A thermos is a type of container.

It is a vacuum-insulated bottle designed to keep liquids hot or cold for extended periods.

Brands like Thermos, Stanley, and Hydro Flask offer various types of thermoses.

Thermoses are commonly used by people who travel, camp, or spend time outdoors. They are essential for keeping beverages at the desired temperature throughout the day.

E-book |

An e-book is a type of book.

It is a digital version of a traditional print book that can be read on electronic devices.

Amazon's Kindle and Apple's iBooks are popular platforms for purchasing and reading e-books.

E-books offer the advantage of portability, as thousands of books can be stored on a single device. They are popular among readers who appreciate the convenience of carrying an entire library wherever they go.



Practice Check

Practice building clear explanations of unfamiliar objects by choosing the best category, definition, example, or extra information.

ITEM 01

Which order is best for a clear cold explanation?

- a) Examples, extra information, category, definition
- b) Category, definition, examples, extra information
- c) Extra information, examples, definition, category
- d) Definition, opinion, examples, category

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 02

Complete the general-domain sentence: A tablet is a type of ____.

- a) computer
- b) meal
- c) instruction
- d) package

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 03

Choose the best definition sentence.

- a) A thermos is nice and many people like it.
- b) A thermos is a container that keeps drinks hot or cold.
- c) A thermos is sometimes on a table.
- d) A thermos is an example of camping.

Correct choice: _____

**ITEM 04**

Which sentence gives examples?

- a) A laptop is a type of computer.
- b) It is small enough to carry.
- c) Apple, Dell, and Lenovo make many laptops.
- d) Laptops can be useful in coffee shops.

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 05

Complete the extra-information sentence: Tablets are often used ____ reading e-books and taking notes.

- a) for
- b) unless
- c) despite
- d) although

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 06

Which sentence is the best opening for explaining 'e-book'?

- a) An e-book is very modern.
- b) An e-book is a type of book.
- c) E-books are popular with many people.
- d) I read an e-book yesterday.

Correct choice: _____

**ITEM 07**

What is the main problem with this explanation? 'It is good, and people use it a lot.'

- a) It gives too many examples.
- b) It is too formal.
- c) It lacks a clear category and definition.
- d) It uses the wrong article.

Correct choice: _____

ITEM 08

Which sentence adds useful extra information about a thermos?

- a) A thermos is a noun.
- b) Some thermoses keep drinks hot for several hours.
- c) Thermos starts with the letter T.
- d) The word thermos is not very long.

Correct choice: _____



Self-check Answer Key

Use the key after you have completed every item on your own.

ITEM 01

b) Category, definition, examples, extra information

ITEM 02

a) computer

ITEM 03

b) A thermos is a container that keeps drinks hot or cold.

ITEM 04

c) Apple, Dell, and Lenovo make many laptops.

ITEM 05

a) for

ITEM 06

b) An e-book is a type of book.

ITEM 07

c) It lacks a clear category and definition.

ITEM 08

b) Some thermoses keep drinks hot for several hours.